

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: A qualified foreign-policy framework

MODERN LABEL -> useful for diplomacy, frontiers, trade and warfare

ANACHRONISM RISK -> no nation-state ministry or fixed sovereign border

COURT ACTORS -> emperor, princes, nobles, governors, envoys and merchants

CORE AIMS -> security, commerce, honour and dynastic influence

VERDICT -> use the label analytically, then state its limits.

MUST REMEMBER: Kandahar, Balkh-Badakhshan and relations with Safavids, Uzbeks and Ottomans
formed different strategic theatres.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Northwest strategic geography

INDIAN CORE -> Delhi / Lahore / Multan supply and revenue base
KABUL - GHAZNI - QANDAHAR -> defensible but porous outer line
QANDAHAR -> junction toward Herat-Iran and the Indus-sea network
BALKH / BADA KHSHAN -> buffer field beyond the Hindukush
SAMARQAND / OXUS -> Timurid memory and contested movement zone
RULE -> schematic routes are not modern international boundaries.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Four-court balance, not a sectarian bloc

MUGHALS -> protect the Indian core and northwest routes

UZBEKS -> pressure Balkh-Badakhshan and can threaten Kabul

SAFAVIDS -> rival over Qandahar but useful counterweight to Uzbeks

OTTOMANS -> prestige, Safavid rivalry and distant maritime context

CALCULATION -> a weaker Iran could strengthen the Uzbek danger

VERDICT -> interest and status qualify Sunni-Shia rhetoric.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Diplomacy as message, intelligence and theatre

MISSION -> elchi or safir carries letters, gifts and oral claims

JOURNEY -> routes, escorts and delays filter information

AUDIENCE -> robes, seating, titles and precedence stage status

OBSERVATION -> envoy reports roads, officials, armies and court mood

RETURN -> gifts and replies preserve ambiguity as well as goodwill

TRAP -> cordial ritual does not settle a territorial claim.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Akbar and the Uzbek balance

1572-73 -> Abdullah Khan takes Balkh; Shahrukh later recovers it

1577 -> anti-Safavid partition proposal; Akbar avoids entanglement

1583 -> Abdullah retakes Balkh | 1585 -> Badakhshan and Kabul change the field

PRACTICAL UNDERSTANDING -> Hindukush restraint, not a fixed treaty border

1595 -> Qandahar passes to Akbar through surrender / defection context

RESULT -> a stronger outer line without Central Asian reconquest.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Why Qandahar mattered

SECURITY -> fort and water base shielding approaches to Kabul

COMMERCE -> caravan junction toward Iran, Central Asia, Multan and the sea

PRESTIGE -> Timurid-imperial honour and a visible frontier claim

ASYMMETRY -> Mughal outer bastion; Iranian outpost linked to Herat

LIMIT -> no single motive or route monopoly explains every crisis

VERDICT -> strategic value changed with power, supply and alternatives.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Jahangir and the loss of 1622

CORDIAL EMBASSIES -> Jahangir underestimates a persistent Safavid claim

SAFAVID INITIATIVE -> Shah Abbas chooses the opportunity to recover Qandahar

FORT CONDITION -> limited readiness and delayed relief weaken defence

COURT POLITICS -> Khurram's response is tied to succession and resource fears

EFFECT -> claim and friendship fail without operational preparation

TRAP -> do not blame Nur Jahan alone or erase Safavid agency.

ASCHII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Shah Jahan recovers Qandahar in 1638

ALI MARDAN KHAN -> Safavid governor faces court and frontier pressure

TRANSFER -> Qandahar passes to Mughal control through defection

MUGHAL RESPONSE -> honour, office and resources consolidate the gain

STRATEGIC RESULT -> outer defence and prestige improve temporarily

LIMIT -> diplomatic tension survives and durable possession is not guaranteed.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Balkh 1646-47: forward defence meets limits

AIM -> influence through a friendly client and pressure beyond Kabul

CAPABILITY -> Mughal armies take Balkh and fight effectively in the field

FRICTION -> winter, distance, supply and noble reluctance raise the cost

POLITICAL LIMIT -> no durable local settlement or compliant client emerges

WITHDRAWAL -> tactical success cannot sustain the occupation

VERDICT -> costly forward defence, not simple cowardice or total collapse.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Why Qandahar resisted recovery, 1649-53

FORTIFICATION -> Safavid defence and terrain favour the holder

ARTILLERY -> siege calibre and effectiveness, not a claim of general weakness

SUPPLY -> long haul from Lahore constrains repeated operations

COMMAND -> coordination, season and pressure narrow the campaign window

THREE ATTEMPTS -> field capacity does not become a successful siege

RESULT -> recovery is abandoned while diplomacy and trade continue.

CLOSE DISTINCTION: Kandahar was a fortress-route-commercial hinge, not merely a prestige symbol in a modern border dispute.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Evidence and the bounded modern bridge

CHRONICLES -> sequence and court claim | patronage and victory language

LETTERS / GIFTS -> status and communication | not private intention

MERCHANTS / TRAVELLERS -> routes and exchange | selective outsider lens

FORTS / MAPS -> material capacity and geography | not policy motive

2026 INDIA-IRAN -> navigation and commerce | analogy, not continuity

METHOD -> match each claim to a source and state its limit.

EVIDENCE LIMIT: Mughal diplomacy used dynastic, commercial and frontier logics; it should not be recast as modern nation-state policy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Topic 19 final answer spine

DEFINE -> qualified court diplomacy across a porous northwest world

MAP -> Indian core, Kabul-Qandahar line, Iran and Balkh field

TRACE -> Akbar balance -> Jahangir 1622 -> Shah Jahan 1638 / 1646-53

EXPLAIN -> security + commerce + honour + dynastic ambition

TEST -> diplomacy, garrison, supply, local allies and source limits

VERDICT -> India-centred defence was central but never the whole story.